

Desk 42: Anomalous Claims

📄 IMPLEMENTATION PLAN & DESIGN ENHANCEMENT BRIEF

👤 SOLO DEV EDITION

Jacob, this is one of the most cohesive GDDs seen from a solo developer. The design thesis is strong, the system interdependencies are well-mapped, and the reference game DNA is precise rather than aspirational. This brief delivers two things: a phase-by-phase implementation plan with concrete architectural decisions, and a design enhancement analysis — gaps, risks, and ideas that push the systems harder.

What This Document Covers

- **Part 1:** Phase-by-phase Unity implementation plan (Phases 0–5)
- **Part 2:** Critical gap analysis — economy, pacing, onboarding
- **Part 3:** 15 design enhancements to push systems further
- **Part 4:** Technical risk table with concrete mitigations

A Note on Scope

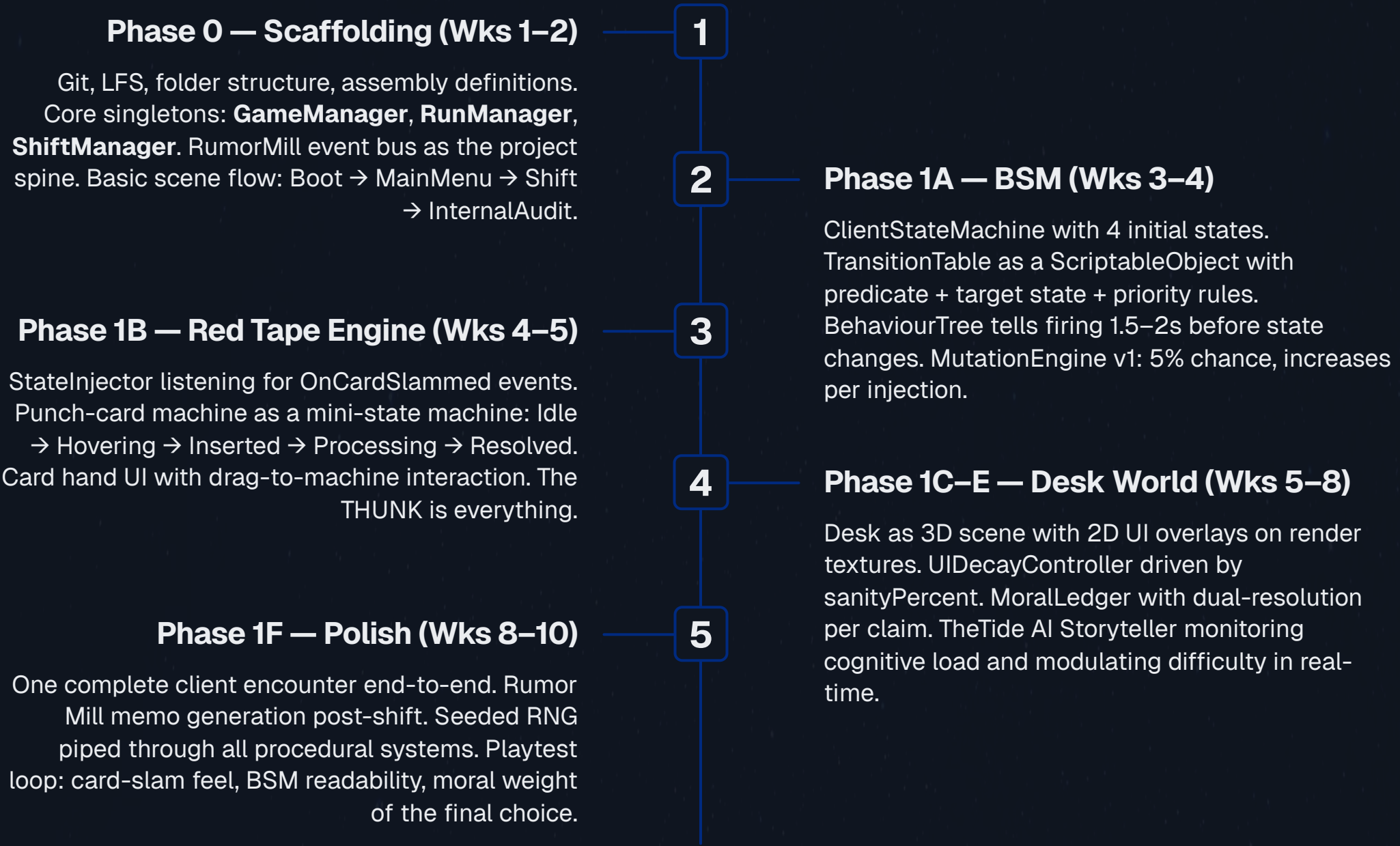
Every recommendation is scoped against Ship Tier first. Update and Expansion Tier features are flagged clearly. For a solo dev, the single most important discipline is **resisting the pull of your own GDD** — the ideas are good, but they must be earned one phase at a time. The vertical slice is everything.

- 📌 Made by an introvert — which means the systems are deep, the documentation is meticulous, and the dark humour lands. Lean into that.

Part 1 — Implementation Plan: Phase 0 & 1

WEEKS 1-10

The first ten weeks are about one thing: getting a single, satisfying client encounter into a playable state. Everything before that is scaffolding. Everything after that builds on this vertical slice. If the card-slam isn't satisfying by Week 10, stop and fix it before moving forward.



Critical Day-1 Architectural Decisions

Decision	Recommendation	Rationale
Behaviour Trees	Custom lightweight BT — ~400 lines with InsertSubtreeAt(int priority, BTNode subtree)	Runtime mutation is non-negotiable. Middleware BT assets do not support injecting subtrees at runtime.
Event System	ScriptableObject Event Bus (Ryan Hipple pattern)	The Rumor Mill IS an event bus. Build it as the global communication layer from day one.
Data Architecture	ScriptableObjects everywhere	Cards, clients, supplies, stamps, tags, regulations — all SOs. Balancing, modding, and iteration become trivial.
Save System	JSON via Newtonsoft — three files: meta.json, run.json, offender_db.json	Repeat Offender DB, Moral Ledger, Conspiracy Board, and meta-progression all persist across runs independently.
UI Framework	UI Toolkit (not UGUI)	CorpOS is a desktop simulation. UI Toolkit's USS styling maps perfectly to "forms, emails, memos as gameplay." UGUI will fight you.
Input	New Input System	Context-sensitive input required: desk mode, stand-up exploration, and punch-card machine are distinct contexts.

Part 1 — Implementation Plan: Phases 2–5

WEEKS 11–36 + POST-LAUNCH

With the vertical slice proven, Phases 2 through 5 build outward systematically — always keeping something playable, always validating before extending. Each phase delivers a testable milestone before the next begins. The order below is the critical path for a solo developer shipping on a fixed timeline.

Phase 2 — Core Loop (Wks 11–20)

- Procedural claim generation: templates × fragments × anomaly tags → 200+ perceivably unique claims from ~40 templates
- Full 4-archetype implementation: Auditor, Gaslighter, Bureaucrat, IT Person — each with unique resource and card pool
- Office Supply system: 15–20 supplies with zone interaction hooks
- Repeat Offender Database: persistent cross-run tactic logging, counter-trait generation at threshold
- NDA overlay system: physical UI elements covering screen quadrants at 4+ and 7+ NDA thresholds
- Internal Audit meta-hub: Employee Handbook skill tree, Conspiracy Board, internal dialogue dials
- Unpaid Overtime death state: Fugue shader, irrational UI, recovery mechanic

Phase 3 — Content & Polish (Wks 21–30)

- Procedural dark humour pipeline: three text generation systems (claim content, rumor mill memos, passive-aggressive UI)
- Binaural audio: Steam Audio HRTF, environmental + mechanical + psychological + musical layers
- Procedural jazz via FMOD or Wwise: desk actions map to MIDI triggers (typing = hi-hat, stamping = snare)
- The Tide narrator polish: 10% unreliability chance, ~200 narrator lines across 4 tone tiers
- Seeded runs & share codes: 32-bit seed displayed as 6-character alphanumeric
- Whistleblower ending: UI shatter shader on render texture, scene transition
- Balancing, juicing, onboarding — tutorial shift with "Gary" memos

Phase 4 — Update Tier (Months 2–4)

- 3 new archetypes: Whistleblower, HR Rep, Intern
- Compliance Vows system (6 vows × 3 ranks)
- Daily Brief mode + Steamworks leaderboard backend
- Departmental Factions + Escalating Regulations
- CorpOS desktop simulation: email, messenger, intranet
- The Reflection mechanic + two remaining endings

Phase 5 — Expansion Tier (Months 5–12)

- Branch Office adventures, Hell Rush, Custom Audits
- Full 11-archetype roster, Office Supply Evolution
- Claim Queue Grid (3×3 spatial adjacency)
- Stand Up From Desk exploration, meta-narrative layers 3–4
- Procedural Corporate Jazz (full implementation)
- Modding tools + Steam Workshop

📌 **Solo Dev Discipline:** Resist the pull of your own GDD. Every sprint, ask: "Is this Ship Tier?" If the answer is no, add it to the backlog and move on. The GDD is a vision document, not a sprint plan.

Part 2 — Critical Gaps in the GDD

GAP ANALYSIS

Four structural gaps exist in the current GDD that, if left unresolved, will cause problems during production. These are not criticisms — they are the natural blind spots of a solo dev thinking deeply about systems without yet having the external feedback loop that exposes pacing and economy issues. Address these before Phase 2 begins.

Gap 1 — Economy Balancing Framework

The GDD describes what costs what but never establishes exchange rates. Without a formal economy model, balancing becomes guesswork. The critical ratio to establish first: expenses should be approximately **70% of a "bureaucratically correct" shift's earnings** and approximately **110% of a "humane" shift's earnings**. This creates the *Papers, Please* tension — you can be good, but you will fall behind on rent. Not immediately. Over three or four shifts.

Currency	Source	Sink	Target/Shift
Corporate Credits	Claim resolution	Supplies, benefits, expenses	Earn 80–120, spend 60–90
Soul Integrity	Starts at 100	Unethical choices (5–15 per)	Meaningful at ~40, critical at ~15
Sanity	Starts at 100	Client interactions, hazards	Drain 2–5/min, recoverable
Audit Points	Compliance Vows	Cosmetics, exclusive benefits	Rare — 1–3 per high-vow run

Gap 2 — Pacing Architecture

A shift needs a dramatic arc. The GDD describes systems but not the beat-by-beat rhythm. Proposed 24-minute structure:

- **Clock In (30s):** Daily Memo, expense reminder, Tide narration
- **Morning Block (8 min):** 3 claims, building intensity — tutorial-weight → medium → first real challenge
- **Lunch Break (2 min):** Shop phase — buy supply OR draft card
- **Afternoon Block (10 min):** 4 claims, peak pressure — difficulty spike, Office Hazard, Repeat Offenders
- **Overtime Window (0–4 min):** Optional risk/reward — bonus claim but sanity is low
- **Clock Out (30s):** Shift Report, expense settlement, Rumor Mill

Hurry Mode compresses this to 12 minutes. The structure gives The Tide clear difficulty escalation points.

Gap 3 — Difficulty Curve Across Runs



Gap 4 — Tutorial & Onboarding Plan

The game is systemically dense. First-time players need a curated first three shifts that introduce complexity gradually. The disappearance of Gary is one of the strongest pieces of environmental storytelling in the GDD — protect it.

Shift 1 — The Orientation
Only PENDING/AGITATED states. Three basic cards. The Tide is genuinely helpful. Colleague Gary explains the punch-card machine step by step. Low stakes, high tutorialisation.

Shift 2 — The Complications Begin
Introduce COOPERATIVE/SUSPICIOUS. NDA system arrives. First moral choice with real cost. Gary's memos become slightly unhinged — still helpful, but something is off.

Shift 3 — The Full Machine
Full BSM unlocked. First Repeat Offender. Gary is gone. His desk is empty. Nobody mentions him. The game has started.

Part 2 — Systems Enhancements: Client & World Design

DESIGN ENHANCEMENTS C5–C7

The Cognitive Budget — Three Gauges, Not One

Currently "sanity" is a single number. Consider splitting it into three interlocking gauges that create genuinely interesting decision space rather than a single bar to manage. The trilemma moments this creates are far richer: "I can handle the aggressive client (Composure drain), but I need Focus to read the corrupted form, and my Resolve is low — a moral choice might trigger Fugue." Each gauge has a distinct failure mode, making recovery decisions strategic rather than reflexive.

Focus

Drained by multi-tasking, NDA clutter, form corruption.
Empty: cards play at half effectiveness.

Composure

Drained by client aggression, jump scares, PARANOID states. **Empty:** BSM tells become invisible.

Resolve

Drained by Moral Injury, expense pressure, coworker betrayal. **Empty:** Fugue State triggers.

Client Species System — Six Families for Ship Tier

The GDD mentions "aliens, eldritch entities, interdimensional beings" but does not formalise species as a gameplay axis. Species should function as a multiplier on existing systems — interacting with counter-traits, anomaly tags, and faction standings — rather than introducing entirely new mechanics. Each species biases the BSM, adds a signature mechanic, and carries its own strand of dark humour.

Species	BSM Bias	Signature Mechanic	Dark Humour Angle
Greys	SUSPICIOUS by default	Claims always contain contradictions	Filing insurance for abductions they themselves committed
Eldritch	DISSOCIATING trigger at low Composure	Form corruption is significantly worse	Perfectly polite. Claims are incomprehensible.
Fae	SMUG, exploit loopholes	Card effects reversed 20% of the time	Every statement is technically true but deliberately misleading
Temporal	Start at random state, shift mid-encounter	Claim references events that have not happened yet	Filing claims for damages caused by your future self
Dimensional	COOPERATIVE but wrong about everything	Multiple valid claim interpretations exist simultaneously	Insists on regulations from their dimension, which may not exist here
Undead	RESIGNED, hard to motivate	Immune to THREATEN, vulnerable to EXPEDITE	Posthumous claims, estate disputes, filing on behalf of a memory

The Supervisor as a Living Threat — Formalised

01

Distant — No Effect

Freedom to act. You can hear footsteps but proximity has no mechanical consequence. This is the default state. Enjoy it.

02

Nearby — Monitored

Protocol compliance is observed. Unethical actions carry a higher detection chance. Recommended: play it straight until they pass.

03

At Your Desk — Performance Review

30-second observation event. You must *appear* efficient. A THREATEN card played while the supervisor watches = instant HR violation. Choose cards carefully.

04

Called to Office — Consequence Event

Triggered by accumulated violations or exceptional performance. The walk to the supervisor's office is a first-person horror corridor. Either a bonus or a penalty — you will not know which until you arrive.

Part 2 — Systems Enhancements: Office Environment

DESIGN ENHANCEMENTS C8–C12

The following enhancements focus on the physical office environment as a systemic space — transforming what could be flavour into mechanics, and what could be dead time into micro-decisions. The office should feel populated, inhabited, and subtly hostile, even when no client is sitting across from you.



The Pneumatic Mail System

A pneumatic tube on the desk delivers unsolicited items from other departments: mislabelled claims (wrong department — bonus challenge to reroute), care packages from sympathetic coworkers, threatening memos from rivals, and anonymous Post-it fragments. The player can also **send** items through the tube — forwarding a claim costs time but avoids moral damage; sending evidence opens the Whistleblower path. Every delivery is a micro-decision, and The Tide can use it to inject mid-encounter curveballs without breaking immersion.



The Coffee Economy

Coffee is a physical resource with genuine mechanical depth. Types include: **black coffee** (Sanity boost, Jitter increase), **decaf** (small Sanity, no Jitter), **espresso** (massive Focus boost, crash timer), and **break room sludge** (random effect). Sharing coffee with a client is the most reliable COOPERATIVE trigger — but you lose a precious resource. Late-shift coffee is stale and delivers reduced or negative effects. The coffee machine in the break room is a character. It dispenses wisdom, complaints, and occasionally prophecy. It is the game's most reliable narrator.



The Filing Cabinet Graveyard

Every claim you process gets physically filed in a cabinet behind your desk. Cabinets fill visibly over the course of a run. You can pull old files for Cross-Claim Deduction. The twist: anomalous claims sometimes **escape**. A poorly-filed claim — one where corners were cut — has a chance to reactivate. The cabinet rattles; paper seeps out; an old claim returns with new mutations. Well-filed claims stay dormant. The filing cabinet becomes a physical representation of your work quality. Your past, in this office, is not metaphorical.

The Answering Machine — Temporal Pressure Layer

The Problem It Solves

Audio threats from the supervisor are one-directional. The player cannot manage them. The answering machine gives the player agency over *when* they engage with information — but at a cost.

Mechanical Depth

- Messages from department heads alter current shift rules
- Warning messages name you specifically
- Trap messages sound helpful but increase Moral Injury
- Unplayed messages auto-play at the worst possible moment

The Client's Desk Mirror

During encounters, the client has their own small desk area visible to you — a briefcase, personal items, family photos. These are procedurally generated and carry mechanical information. A family photo means the client has something to lose (THREATEN is more effective but morally worse). A lawyer's business card means backup is available (LITIGIOUS transition accelerates). A stress ball signals pre-existing anxiety (COOPERATIVE is easier to reach).

High-empathy players read the desk to find humane solutions. High-efficiency players read it to find weaknesses. The same information supports opposite moral interpretations — which is exactly what good systemic design does.

The Employee ID Badge

Always visible on the desk. Shows name, department, clearance level, and a photo that degrades with Moral Injury. Required for clearance-gated filing cabinets and faction-locked claim types. If a client steals it — a rare, deeply uncomfortable event — you temporarily lose clearance. Your own systems no longer recognise you.

Part 2 — Mechanical Enhancements: Deep Systems

DESIGN ENHANCEMENTS C13–C15

Card Fatigue — Enforcing the "Read and Adapt" Philosophy

Optimal play in card games frequently devolves into finding the best card and repeating it indefinitely. Card Fatigue is the mechanical enforcement of the design philosophy already present in the GDD. Each punch card has a Fatigue counter that increments with repeated use in a single shift. The result is that even an objectively correct strategy forces tactical pivots — which, given the BSM's mutation system, is precisely the behaviour you want to reward.

	Fatigue 1–2 — Nominal Card performs normally. No visible indication beyond a subtle wear mark on the card texture.
	Fatigue 3 — Card Jams Brief machine lockout. The Bureaucrat archetype has reduced Fatigue accumulation — their efficiency theme made mechanical.
	Fatigue 5 — Card Crumpled Card removed for the remainder of the shift. IT Person can reset Fatigue with Debug tokens. This is not a punishment — it is a puzzle.

The Stress Roll Virtue/Vice System

The GDD mentions "Virtues during stress rolls" but leaves the system undefined. Stress Rolls trigger when Sanity crosses a threshold (every 25%). The roll produces either a Virtue or a Vice. Crucially, the **probability is weighted by Moral Injury** — low MI favours Virtues, high MI favours Vices. This makes the Moral Injury axis mechanically crisp: it is not flavour, it directly alters gameplay through the probability distribution of stress roll outcomes.

Virtues (Low Moral Injury)

Clarity Next 3 cards cost 0 to play.	Compassion Client immediately enters COOPERATIVE.
Resolve Sanity cannot drop below current value for 30 seconds.	Whisper of Truth All hidden traits revealed for 15 seconds.

Vices (High Moral Injury)

Paranoia All clients treated as SUSPICIOUS for 60 seconds.	Numbness Card effects reduced by 50% for 2 encounters.
Cruelty Next THREATEN card auto-plays without player input.	Dissociation Random UI elements become unresponsive for 20 seconds.

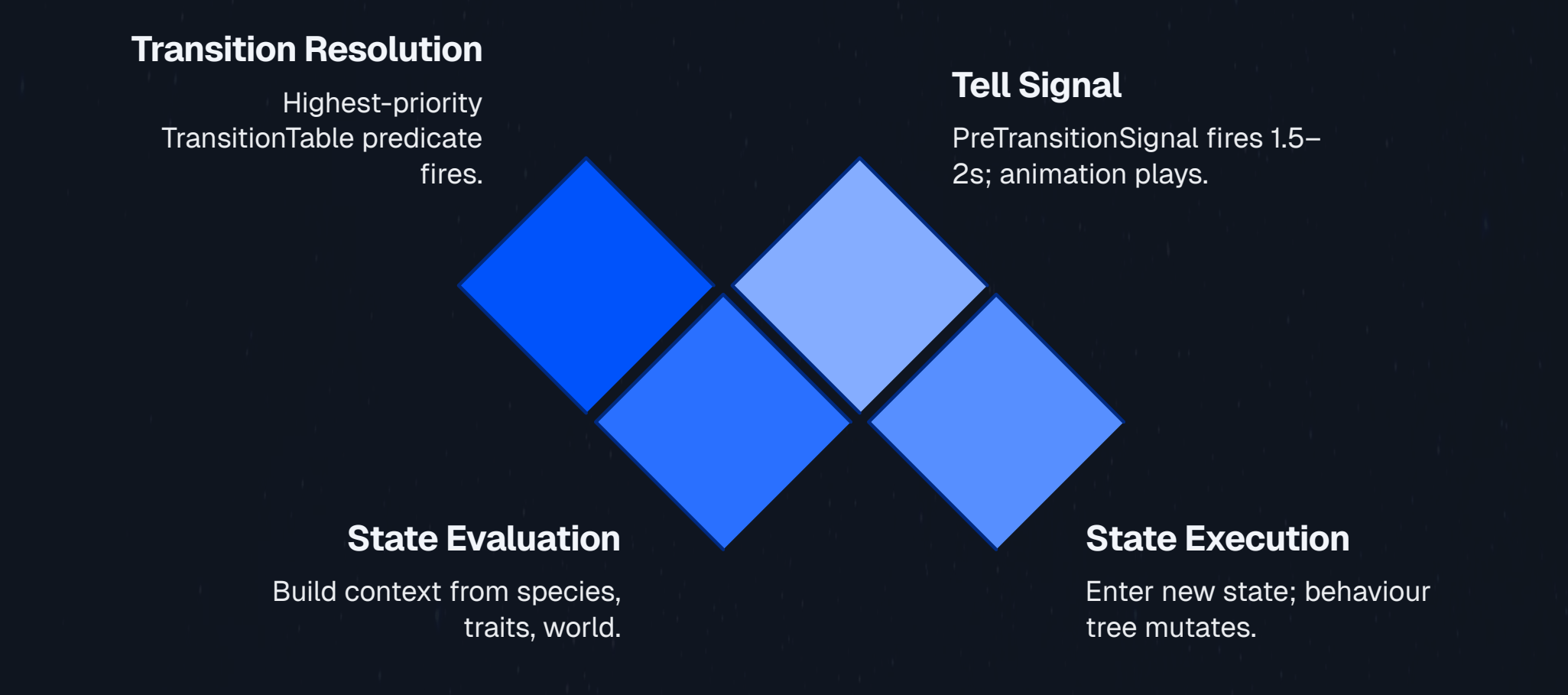
The Redaction Mechanic — Gaslighter Enhancement

REDACT cards are described in the GDD but the mechanic lacks depth. When the Gaslighter plays REDACT, the player physically drags a black bar across specific words on the claim form. The redacted information is removed from the client's memory — they can no longer reference it during the encounter. The depth comes from the risk: redacting the claim *amount* makes the client forget what they are owed (good for you), but redacting the *incident description* renders the claim unresolvable — forcing a REASSIGN that costs time. The player must read the claim and choose strategically what to black out. This turns the Gaslighter into a **reading-comprehension archetype**. The most literate player wins. For a game made by an introvert, this is exactly the right design space.

Part 3 — The Bureaucratic State Machine: Architecture

TECHNICAL DEEP DIVE

The BSM is the engine of every client encounter. Getting its architecture right in Phase 1 determines whether the entire game feels readable, learnable, and fair. The following structural decisions are non-negotiable for a system with this many interdependencies.



The key architectural insight of the TransitionTable is that the same player action produces five different outcomes depending on context. This is what separates the BSM from a simple state machine — transitions are functions of world state, not just player input. Office temperature, Moral Injury level, faction standings, visit count, and counter-traits all feed into the context that the TransitionTable evaluates.

Custom Behaviour Tree — Node Types Required

**Selector**

Tries children in order, succeeds on first success. The core branching mechanism for client decision-making under different emotional states.

**Sequence**

Runs children in order, fails on first failure. Used for client "plans" — multi-step agendas that can be interrupted by card injection.

**Decorator**

Conditional wrapper: cooldown, probability, state-check. Wraps action nodes to add conditions without duplicating logic across the tree.

**InjectionSlot**

Special node where punch cards insert subtrees. This is the entire Red Tape Engine, reduced to a single node type. Protect its API carefully.

**MutationNode**

A node that can rewrite itself after N triggers. The MutationEngine watches for repeated successful injections and probabilistically inserts counter-nodes: Pre-Filed Exemption, Retained Counsel, Photographic Memory.

"The Repeat Offender Database persists counter-traits across runs. The game gets harder the more you play — but differently, not just numerically. This distinction is everything."

Archetype Unique Resources — Implementation Priority

Archetype	Unique Resource	Implementation Notes	Priority
Auditor	Standard card draw	Already complete from vertical slice. Control playstyle, PENDING_REVIEW/LEGAL_HOLD focus.	Phase 1 ✓
Gaslighter	Doubt tokens	New TokenManager<DoubtToken>. High doubt on a claim field = client self-withdrawal. Redaction mechanic.	Phase 2A
Bureaucrat	Efficiency meter	UI gauge. Cards fill it. Speed-processing mini-game at full meter. Reduced Fatigue accumulation.	Phase 2B
IT Person	Debug tokens	Requires visible BT representation. Debug tokens as BTModifierNode overlays. Stack Overflow at 5+ = system crash event.	Phase 2C

Part 4 — Technical Risk Analysis

RISK REGISTER

The following risks are specific to the technical architecture of Desk 42. They are not hypothetical — each one has caused production problems in games with similar system profiles. Address mitigations proactively rather than reactively; several of these become exponentially harder to fix once content is in production.

Critical — Scope Creep from GDD Ambition The GDD has 61 sections for a solo developer. The risk is not that the ideas are bad — they are excellent — but that the pull of interesting systems will derail Ship Tier delivery. Mitigation: Ship Tier is ruthlessly scoped and locked. Every sprint, ask: "Is this Ship Tier?" If the answer is no, add it to a versioned backlog and move on. Use the phase plan in this document as the locked sprint boundary.	High — Behaviour Tree Performance at Scale Trees tick every frame per client. With multiple clients, complex trees, and mutation nodes, this can easily exceed frame budgets. Mitigation: Tick budgeting — max 2ms/frame for BT evaluation. Pool and reuse nodes. Spread ticks across frames for multi-client encounters. Build the debug overlay early (see Technical Recommendations) to profile BT cost per frame from the start.
High — Combinatorial Explosion in Synergy Testing Five layers of synergies (cards × supplies × states × species × regulations) create a state space that is effectively untestable by hand. Mitigation: Automated synergy validation tests. Define "legal" vs "broken" thresholds. Embrace broken combos as rewards — they become discovered secrets — but flag true softlocks automatically. A combo that trivialises one archetype's run is a feature; a combo that makes the game unresolvable is a bug.	Medium — Save System Complexity Cross-run persistent data (Repeat Offender DB, Moral Ledger, Meta-progress) combined with mid-run state creates a complex serialisation problem. Mitigation: Three separate files: meta.json (never lost, cross-run), run.json (deletable, mid-run), offender_db.json (persistent, versioned). Version every schema from day one. Migration scripts are cheap to write; corrupt save files are expensive to debug.
Medium — Seeded Determinism Bugs Any non-deterministic code silently breaks seed replay. This is a guarantee, not a risk. Mitigation: Route ALL random through SeedEngine. Never call UnityEngine.Random directly — enforce this with a custom static analyser or code review checklist. Automated seed regression tests: run the same seed twice, assert identical outputs. Build this from Phase 0.	Medium — Procedural Claim Content Quality Generated text can feel soulless if the template pool is too small or too uniform. Mitigation: Hybrid approach — hand-write 200+ template fragments with genuine comedic voice, combine procedurally. Quality floor matters more than procedural ceiling. The dark humour in this GDD is distinctive; that voice must be in every fragment, not just the headlines.

Technical Recommendations — Non-Negotiable

1 Unity Addressables from Day One When you reach 200+ cards, 50+ supplies, and 40+ client templates, loading everything at startup tanks performance. Addressables load content on demand and make DLC and modding trivial. This is also a prerequisite for Steam Workshop in Expansion Tier — retrofitting Addressables onto an existing project is deeply unpleasant.	2 Debug Console with Command Vocabulary Build this from day one. Commands: give_supply RedPen, set_sanity 25, force_state LITIGIOUS, skip_to_q3, trigger_memo TaxFraud. This is a two-day investment that saves 200+ hours during development. The BSM visualiser overlay (current state, active BT, injection stack, transition probabilities) belongs here too.
3 Replay Recording via Input + Seed Record every input and the master seed — not game state. A 30-minute run compresses to approximately 50KB of inputs. This delivers: deterministic bug reproduction, sharable replays for community engagement, and The Hell Rush spectator mode for free. It is also the correct approach to automated regression testing.	4 Frame-Deferred Rumor Mill Events An event bus connecting every system is powerful but can become a performance bottleneck when events cascade synchronously. Implement a frame-deferred queue: events fire, get queued, and process in batch at end-of-frame. This prevents cascading chains from causing frame spikes — critical for a game where a single card slam can trigger six simultaneous system responses.

Closing Notes — A Brief for an Introvert

☆ FINAL RECOMMENDATIONS

There is something quietly appropriate about Desk 42 being made by a solo developer working alone — an introvert building a game about the psychic cost of performing competence in public, processing impossible demands in silence, and watching the world slowly stop making sense. The game's themes are not just design choices; they are a specific kind of creative honesty. That is why the GDD lands so well. Protect that voice through production.

The Three Things That Must Be True at Ship Tier

- **The card-slam must feel satisfying.** Not good. Satisfying. The THUNK is the tactile heartbeat of every session. Get the audio and haptic feedback right before anything else. If players don't feel the machine, nothing downstream matters.
- **The moral choice must cost something.** Not in credits — emotionally. The economy model in this brief is designed to ensure that players feel the slow accumulation of a choice made three shifts ago. Test this rigorously in playtesting. If testers say "I didn't notice the moral system," the economy is miscalibrated.
- **The BSM must be learnable, then surprising.** Players must be able to read clients. They must be able to form strategies. And then — at the exact moment they feel clever — the mutation system must prove them wrong. That cycle of confidence and disruption is the entire game.

The One Risk Worth Naming Directly

The GDD is genuinely exceptional — and that is, paradoxically, the greatest risk. Exceptional GDDs create their own gravitational field. Every new idea you have will feel like it belongs in Ship Tier. Every enhancement in this brief will feel urgent. The discipline required is to treat the GDD as a completed design document, not a live one, from the moment Phase 1 begins.

Ship Tier is a complete, coherent, deeply satisfying game. Update and Expansion Tier are bonuses — earned by shipping, not planned into existence. The solo dev who ships a focused, polished vertical slice beats the solo dev with a 61-section GDD and an empty build folder every time.

☐ The desk at Desk 42 has processed thousands of claims. The wear marks prove it. The game you are building is the one that gets finished.

Recommended Next Action

Open Unity. Create the project. Set up the folder structure from Phase 0. Commit the empty scaffold to Git. The plan is only valuable once it has a running build to attach itself to.

36

Weeks to Ship Tier

Phases 0–8, solo dev velocity, with polish and playtesting included.

200+

Unique Claims at Launch

From ~40 templates and ~100 fragment pools — perceivably distinct through combinatorial composition.

15

Design Enhancements

Specific, actionable ideas in this brief — all scoped against existing systems, none requiring new ones.

1

Non-Negotiable Priority

The vertical slice. If the single shift loop isn't fun by Week 10, nothing else matters.